

of Zeus. You, my brother, with your rod of gold, do not bid me reveal any of the divine plans which far-seeing Zeus is devising. I shall hurt some and help others, as I cause great perplexity for the masses of unhappy human beings. The person will profit from my utterance who comes under the guidance of the flight and the cry of my birds of true omen. This is the one who will profit from my utterance and whom I will not deceive; but the one who trusts the birds of meaningless chatter will seek to find out my prophecies and to know more than the eternal gods, quite against my will. I declare that for this one the journey will be in vain, but I would take his gifts anyway. (533–549)

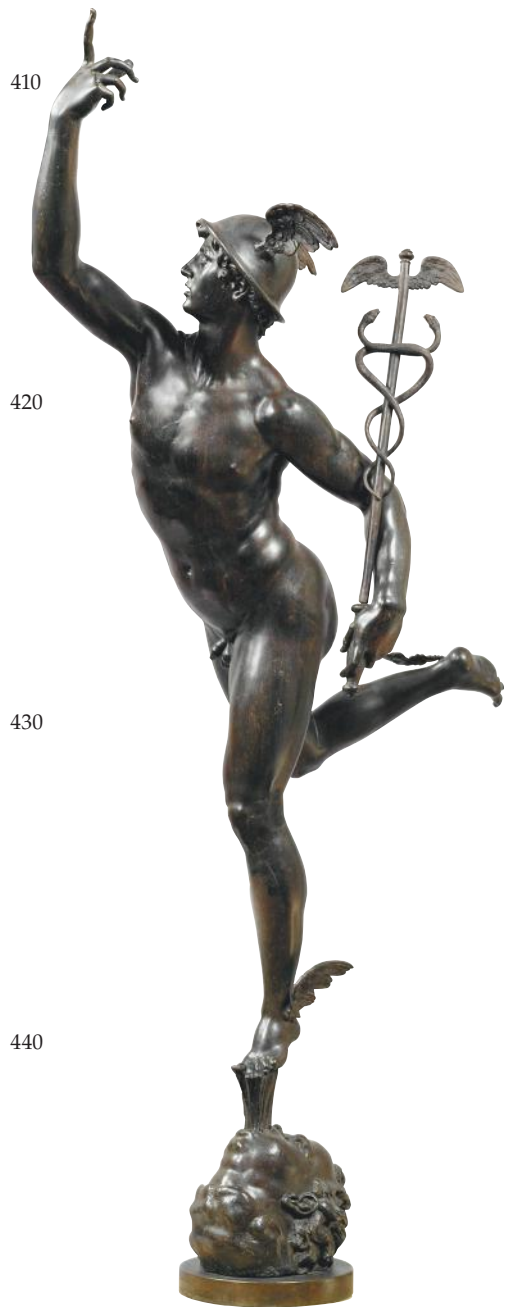
“I shall tell you another thing, son of illustrious Maia and aegis-bearing Zeus, O divine luck-bringer of the gods: indeed, certain holy sisters have been born, three virgins, glorying in their swift wings and having on their heads a sprinkling of white barley, and they live under a ridge of Mt. Parnassus;¹⁰ set apart, they are masters of divination, an art I practiced while still a lad tending cattle and my father did not mind. Then from their home they fly from one place to another and feed from every honeycomb until it is empty. When they have eaten the yellow honey, they become inspired and willingly desire to speak the truth; but if they are deprived of the sweet food of the gods, they gather in a swarm and tell lies. These sisters I give to you; inquire of them carefully and take pleasure in your heart. If then you inform mortal persons, they will listen to what you say often, if they are fortunate. Have these things, son of Maia, and care for the horned oxen of the field, the toiling mules and the horses.” (550–568)

Thus he spoke, and from heaven father Zeus himself added a final pledge to his words: he ordered that glorious Hermes be the lord of all birds of good omen, fierce-eyed lions, boars with gleaming tusks, dogs, and every flock and herd that the wide earth nourishes; and that he alone would be the ordained messenger to Hades, who, although he accepts no gifts, will grant this, by no means the least of honors. (569–573)

So lord Apollo loved the son of Maia in an all-encompassing friendship; and Zeus, the son of Cronus, bestowed on him a beguiling charm. He associates with mortals and immortals. On occasion he gives profit or help to a few, but for the most part he continually deceives human beings by the horde in the blackness of night. (574–578)

So hail to you, son of Zeus and Maia; yet I shall remember both you and another song too.

This artful hymn to Hermes has been much admired; the English poet Percy Bysshe Shelley (1792–1822) himself was one of its translators. The glib and playful treatment of both Hermes and Apollo is often labeled typically Greek.¹¹ It is typically Greek only if we mean by typical *one* of the many brilliant facets of Hellenic genius and a suggestion of the wide variety and scope in the conception of deity. Sincere profundity in religion and philosophy are as typically Greek as wit and facetious sophistication.



Mercury, by Giovanni Bologna (known as Giambologna, 1529–1608); bronze, 1576; height 25 in. Giambologna has taken the classical attributes of Hermes—the petasus, caduceus, and winged sandals—and combined them with the nude figure of a running man to create a masterpiece of Late Renaissance Mannerism. (Alinari/Art Resource, NY)

The Nature of Hermes and His Worship

Many of Hermes' characteristics and powers are evident from the poem. The Greek admiration for cleverness is readily apparent; it is this same admiration that condones the more dubious traits of the hero Odysseus. Anthropomorphism and liberalism are both pushed to their extreme in the depiction of the god Hermes as a thief and in the implication that thieves too must have their patron deity. Divine Hermes, like Prometheus, represents another (albeit extreme) example of the **archetypal trickster**. Yet in delightful, archetypal variations, the major quest of this charming young rogue is extremely dubious—a robbery—and, moreover, is accomplished when he is only a little baby!

The similarities between Hermes and Apollo are equally apparent. They share pastoral and musical characteristics, and the origins of both were probably rooted in the same pastoral society of shepherds with their interest in flocks, music, and fertility. The Sicilian shepherd **Daphnis** was the son of Hermes and a nymph and became the inventor of pastoral music and a leading character in the pastoral poetry of Theocritus. Hermes and Apollo are alike in appearance, splendid examples of vigorous and handsome masculinity. But Hermes is the younger and more boyish, the idealization and patron of youths in their late teens; his statue belonged in every gymnasium. Hermes is perhaps best known as the divine messenger, often delivering the dictates of Zeus himself; as such he wears a traveler's hat (**petasus**) and sandals (**talaria**) and carries a herald's wand (**caduceus**), which sometimes bears two snakes entwined. The entwined snakes may be a symbol for Hermes as a fertility god, connected with the Underworld. The staff of Hermes became confused with the staff of the physician Asclepius, for whom serpents represented new life, since they could slough their old skins (see p. 262). Wings may be depicted on Hermes' hat, his sandals, and even his wand. Thus he is also the god of travelers and roads. As the guide of souls (**psychopompos**) to the realm of Hades under the earth, he provides another important function, which reminds us once again of his fertility connections.

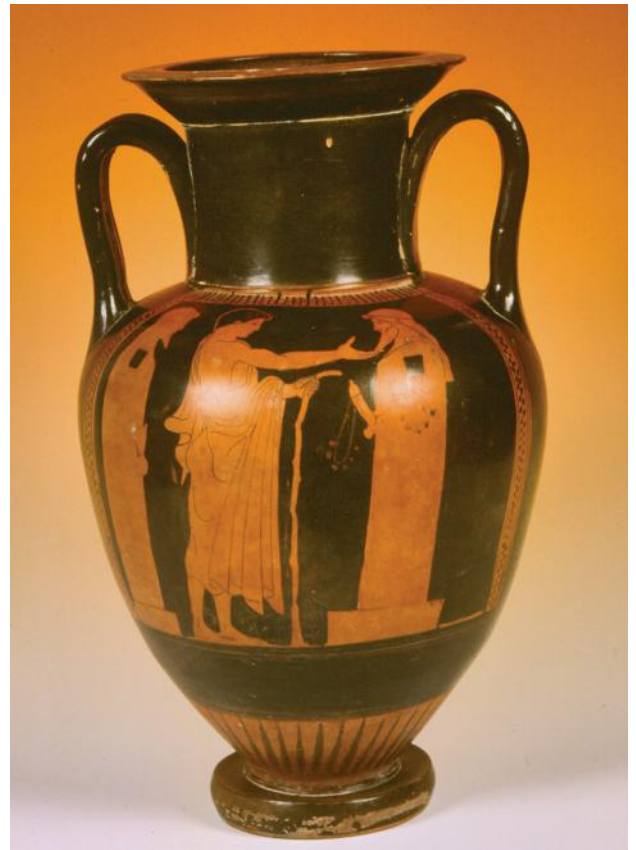
Statues of Hermes, called herms (singular, herm), were common in the ancient world and were symbols of fertility. They were intended to bring prosperity

The Mutilation of the Herms

Many ancient Greeks did believe in their gods. A historical incident concerning herms warns us to be wary of facile generalizations about Greek religious attitudes. In 415 B.C., on the eve of the great Athenian expedition against Sicily, the herms in the city of Athens were mutilated during the night. The religious scandal that ensued became a political football; the general Alcibiades was charged, and the consequences were serious—quite a fuss over phallic statues of a god in a period fraught with sophistic skepticism, agnosticism, and atheism. Alcibiades was also charged with the parody and desecration of the Eleusinian mysteries of Demeter in a private home; he called himself Hierophant and wore a robe like that of the high priest when he shows the holy secrets to the initiates (Plutarch, *Alcibiades* 22. 3; see also Thucydides 6. 27–29).

and luck. In the classical period, a herm might be found outside any house; and these herms could be taken very seriously. In appearance, they were square pillars equipped with male genitals; on top of each was the head of Hermes. These phallic statues probably marked areas regarded as sacred or designated, at least originally, the bounds of one's home or property.

Nilsson's theory about the origins of Hermes and his depiction as a herm is of interest.¹² There were various stone cults in Greece such as the one at Delphi in connection with the omphalos. It was believed that a divine power (*daimon*) resided in the stone, which was anointed and covered with sacred wool (see p. 251). On the top of a grave mound, which was often composed of lesser stones, a tall stone was erected. Passersby would add their stones to the mound, making it a guiding landmark. The god Hermes, whose name means "he from the stone-heap," was believed to live in this landmark grave-mound, and so he became the guide and protector of travelers and also of souls on their way to the Underworld. Subsequently,



Hermes. Athenian red-figure krater (left) and red-figure amphora by the Pan painter (right), both 470–460 B.C. These images show how Hermes and his phallic statues were part of the life of ordinary citizens at Athens. On the left a young woman clasps the shoulders of the god to whom she prays, perhaps before offering a simple sacrifice on the altar beside the herm. On the right a young man, standing between two herms and touching the god's beard in a traditional gesture of supplication, offers a garland and a prayer, perhaps before going on a journey. The god is the object of humble prayers for success, be it in love or business or travel. (Left: *Bildarchiv Preussischer Kulturbesitz/Art Resource, NY*) (Right: *Musée d'Art et d'Archéologie de Laon*)

Hermes Trismegistus

Hermes came to be equated with the Egyptian god Thoth and thus began to acquire some of his attributes as a god of magic, knowledgeable in things mystic and occult. In this transformation, he was given the epithet Trismegistus, which means thrice great (an appellation denoting a superlative, “great, great, great”). Hermes Trismegistus (supposedly the grandson of Hermes the god and not the god himself) is said to have composed many books on various aspects of Egyptian religion. The extant corpus of works attributed to him is referred to as the *Hermetica* (*Discourses of Hermes*) or *Hermetic Writings*. Topics deal with philosophy, astrology, and alchemy and despite some Egyptian influence are essentially Greek in character. These texts belong to the Hellenistic period (in the fourth century) after the time of Plato, whose influence is evident.

his abode, a monumental stone on a stone-heap, was regarded as his image (a herm) and given a human head. A herm never became fully anthropomorphic, and it continued to offer guidance for travelers and protection for graves, roads, and streets, and also to provide many blessings for homes.

To sum up, many of the functions of Hermes can be characterized by his role as a creator and crosser of boundaries and an intermediary between two different worlds. His herms served to mark the boundaries between one’s property and that of another and what has to be bridged. As a messenger of the gods, Hermes joins the human with the divine realm of the Olympians; as psychopompos, he brings mortals across the barriers of the Underworld. As a god of young men, Hermes stands as an exemplar of the critical rite of passage between youth and adulthood. Finally, in relation to Hermes and the crossing of established boundaries, consider the story of Hermaphroditus, a figure who unites the attributes of both sexes but transgresses the limitations of gender.

Hermaphroditus and Salmacis

Among the adventures and affairs of Hermes, his union with Aphrodite is important because of their offspring, Hermaphroditus, whose story is told by Ovid (*Metamorphoses* 4. 285–388):

Let me tell you how the fountain Salmacis got its bad reputation and why it weakens and softens limbs touched by its enervating waters.¹³ This power of the fountain is very well known; the reason for it lies hidden. A son was born to Mercury and Venus, and Naiads brought him up in the cave of Mt. Ida. You could recognize his mother and father in his beauty, and his name also came from them. As soon as he reached the age of fifteen, he left the hills of his homeland. When he had departed from Ida, the mountain that had nurtured him, he took delight in wandering over unknown lands and in seeing unknown rivers; his zeal made the hardships easy. (285–295)

Then he came to the cities of the Lycians and their neighbors the Carians. 10
 There he saw a pool of water that was clear to the very bottom with no marsh
 reeds, barren sedge, or sharp-pointed rushes to be seen. The water was trans-
 parent in its clarity, and the edge of the pool was surrounded by fresh turf and
 grass that was always green. (296–301)

A nymph lived here; but one who was not inclined to hunt and not in the habit
 of bending the bow or contending in the chase. She alone of the Naiads was
 unknown to swift Diana. It is told that her sisters often said to her: “Salmacis,
 take up a javelin or a lovely painted quiver; vary the routine of your idleness with
 the strenuous exercise of the hunt.” She did not take up the javelin or the lovely
 painted quiver and did not vary the routine of her idleness with the strenuous 20
 exercise of the hunt. Instead she would only bathe her beautiful limbs in her
 fountain and often comb out her hair with a comb of boxwood and look into
 the water to see what suited her best; and then she would clothe her body in a
 transparent garment and recline on the soft leaves or the soft grass. Often she
 picked flowers. (302–315)

Hermaphroditus

Ovid’s narrative of Salmacis and Hermaphroditus has dominated the literary and artistic tradition, obscuring the factual account of the first-century B.C. author Vitruvius, who explained the weakness caused by the pool of Salmacis as an allegory for the civilizing of local tribes by Greek settlers. Ovid’s source was a collection of tales from Asia Minor, one of them concerning Salmacis, a pool near Halicarnassus in Caria, beside which was a temple dedicated to Hermes and Aphrodite. The name Hermaphroditus was first used by the philosopher Theophrastus in about 320 B.C., describing how on the fourth and seventh days of the month (the fourth day was sacred to Hermes and Aphrodite) the superstitious man “spends all day putting wreaths on the Hermaphrodites.” By this time Hermaphroditus was worshiped as a god embodying the union of Hermes, with his erect phallus (see p. 293), and Aphrodite, as the physical expression of female fertility. He was, then, a minor fertility god, described by the historian Diodorus Siculus in the first century B.C. as “very like Priapus” (see p. 192), but his reputation received a boost from Polycles’ statue (which was said to have “made him noble”). Nevertheless, Ovid’s story, with its explicit focus on emasculation and physical weakness, has concealed whatever divine authority Hermaphroditus may once have held, and at Rome hermaphrodites were considered to be ill-omened prodigies and were drowned. Bisexuality is significant in Greek mythology and philosophy, as it is in nature. In the Orphic hymns Phanes, the original creator of everything, is bisexual. In Plato’s *Symposium*, Aristophanes explains how Zeus divided human beings into three sexes, with each individual seeking its other half (see pp. 209–212). These serious religious and philosophical allegories gave way to voyeuristic interest in bisexual human beings, furthered in literature by Ovid’s tale and in art by such works as the sculpture on p. 296. From Ovid came countless poetic elaborations from Spenser to Swinburne, while eighty artistic representations survive from the ancient world. Essential reading for Hermaphroditus is the article (in English) by Aileen Ajootian in *Lexikon Iconographicum Mythologiae Classicae*, Vol. 1, pp. 269–285.

Salmacis was picking flowers as it happened when she saw the boy Hermaphroditus. As soon as she saw him, she desired to have him. Although she was anxious to hasten to him, she did not approach until she had composed herself, arranged her garment, and assumed a beautiful countenance. When she looked as attractive as she ought, she began to speak as follows: “Lovely boy, most worthy to be believed a god; if you are a god, you could be Cupid; if a mortal, blessed are your parents, and happy your brother and fortunate indeed your sister, if you have one, and the nurse who gave you her breast. But by far the most blessed of all is your betrothed, if she exists, whom you will consider worthy of marriage. If you have such a beloved, let my passion be satisfied in secret, but if you do not, let me be the one and let us go together to our marriage bed.” With this the nymph was silent. (315–329)



A Hermaphrodite. Roman marble copy of a Greek bronze by Polykles of the mid-second century B.C.: marble mattress added by Gian-Lorenzo Bernini in 1620. Length 58 in. Hermaphrodites were popular from the fourth century onward in the Greek and (later) Roman worlds. The discovery of this one in Rome in 1608 led to fascination with the subject and the manufacture of many copies in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. It was presented to Cardinal Scipione Borghese, for whom Bernini made the mattress. The room in which it was displayed in his villa at Rome was later decorated with a fresco of the legend of Salmacis and Hermaphroditus. Napoleon (whose brother-in-law was a Borghese) bought the statue in 1807, and by 1811 it was on display in Paris, where it has remained. The male and female sexual attributes in the same figure have always intrigued viewers, while in the eighteenth century a cynical English tourist remarked that it was “the only happy couple that she ever saw.” (*Erich Lessing/ Art Resource, NY*)

A blush flared up in the boy's face, for he did not know what love was. But the flush of red was becoming; his was the color of apples hanging in a sunny orchard or of tinted marble or of the moon, a reddish glow suffusing its whiteness. . . . To the nymph, as she demanded without end at least the kisses of a sister and brought her hand to touch his ivory neck, he exclaimed: "Are you going to stop, or am I to flee and leave you and your abode?" Salmacis was frightened and replied: "I give over to you free access to this place, my guest and friend." She turned her step away and pretended to depart, though still with a glance back. She concealed herself in a hidden grove of bushes, dropping on bended knees. But he moved on the deserted grass from one spot to another, confident that he was not being watched and gradually dipped his feet as far as the ankles in the playful waves. (329–343) 40

Taken by the feel of the captivating waters, with no delay he threw off the soft clothes from his body. Then, to be sure, Salmacis was transfixed, enflamed with desire for his naked form. Her eyes, too, were ablaze just as if the radiant orb of the glowing sun were reflected in their mirror. With difficulty she endured the agony of waiting, with difficulty she held off the attainment of her joy. Now she longed to embrace him, now in her frenzy she could hardly contain herself. He swiftly struck his hollow palms against his sides and plunged into the pool, and as he moved one arm and then the other he glistened in the limpid water like an ivory statue or a lily that one has encased within clear glass. The nymph cried out: "I have won, he is mine!" And she flung off all her clothes and threw herself into the middle of the waves. She held him as he fought and snatched kisses as he struggled; she grasped him with her hands and touched his chest and now from this side and now from that enveloped the youth. (344–360) 50 60

Finally, she encircled him as he strove against her in his desire to escape, like a serpent which the king of birds has seized and carried aloft, and which as it hangs binds the eagle's head and feet and with its tail enfolds the spreading wings, even as ivy is wont to weave around tall trunks of trees or as the octopus grabs and holds fast its enemy in the deep with tentacles let loose on every side. Hermaphroditus, the descendant of Atlas, endured and denied the nymph the joys that she had hoped for. She continued her efforts, and her whole body clung to him as though they were glued together. She cried: "You may fight, cruel villain, but you will not escape. May the gods so ordain and may we never be separated in future time, you from me or me from you." The gods accepted her prayer. (361–373) 70

For their two bodies were joined together as they entwined, and in appearance they were made one, just as when one grafts branches on a tree and sees them unite in their growth and become mature together; thus, when their limbs united in their close embrace, they were no longer two but a single form that could not be called girl or boy and appeared at the same time neither one, but both. And so, when he saw that the limpid waters into which he had gone as a man had made him half a man and in them his limbs had become enfeebled, Hermaphroditus stretched out his hands and prayed in a voice that was no longer masculine: "Father and mother, grant this gift to your son who bears both your names. Let whatever man who enters this pool come out half a man and let him suddenly become soft when touched by its waves." Both parents were moved and granted the wish of their child, who was now of a double nature, and they tainted the waters with this foul power. (373–388) 80

Statues of Hermaphroditus and hermaphrodites became common in the fourth century and in the following Hellenistic period, when Greek masters strove to vary their repertoires with fascinating and brilliantly executed studies in the realistic, erotic, and unusual.

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Homeric Hymn 18	<i>To Hermes</i>
Ovid	<i>Metamorphoses</i> 4.285–388

Additional Sources

Lucian	<i>Dialogues of the Gods: Hermes and Maia</i>
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The following are ancient sources for the historical incidents of the mutilation of the Herms, the desecration of the Mysteries, and the charges against Alcibiades and others.

Andocides	<i>On the Mysteries</i>
Thucydides	<i>History of the Peloponnesian War</i> 6.27.1–6.29.3

Notes

1. The live tortoise was believed to be a taboo against harm and sorcery.
2. This is probably the well-known Pieria near Mt. Olympus in northern Thessaly. On his journey from Pieria, Hermes passes through Onchestus, situated between Thebes and Orchomenus, and brings the cattle to the river Alpheus, which flows near Olympia in the western Peloponnesus.
3. As he walks along, Hermes makes the cattle walk backward. Thus the hoofprints of the cattle will seem to be going toward the meadow and not out of it. Hermes' own tracks will be obscured by his sandals.

4. As we have seen, according to Hesiod (*Theogony* 387), Selene is the daughter of Hyperion and Theia; Pallas (*Theogony* 375, 377, 409) was the son of the Titan Crius; and his brother Perses was the father of Hecate. Megamedes is not found elsewhere.
5. The text is corrupt at this point; apparently, Hermes used the laurel branch to rub against a piece of wood grasped in the palm of his hand, thus creating the friction to produce fire.
6. Hermes offers a portion to each of the twelve gods. According to sacrificial ritual, he (as one of them) must not eat his portion or those of the other gods but merely savor the aroma.
7. Presumably Apollo intends to bind either Hermes or the cows.
8. The lyre is mentioned as a beloved companion, that is, a girlfriend, and in the next few lines Hermes sustains the metaphor, which reads naturally in Greek but is difficult to render in English. Thus she will accompany Apollo to the feast and the dance, and she will behave and respond as a beloved should, if only she is treated in the right way.
9. These are shepherds' pipes of reed, also called panpipes since they are often said to be the invention of the god Pan. Hermes sometimes is named as the father of Pan, whom he resembles in certain respects.
10. These are identified as the Thriae; their name means "pebbles." Thus they are the eponymous nymphs of divining pebbles, that is, pebbles used for divination. They appear to be women with wings. Probably their hair is literally powdered with white flour; some suggest that they are meant to be white-haired and old or that the image intended is that of bees covered with pollen.
11. In tone and mood, this story is not unlike that of Aphrodite, Ares, and Hephaestus in Homer (*Odyssey* 8. 266–366, translated in Chapter 5, pp. 128–130).
12. See Martin P. Nilsson, *A History of Greek Religion*. Translated by F. J. Fielden. 2d. ed. New York: W. W. Norton, 1952 [1964], pp. 109–110.
13. In context, Alcithoë is telling the story to her sisters. The spring Salmacis was located at Halicarnassus.



Dionysus, Pan, Echo, and Narcissus

Reenactment of the Marriage of Dionysus and Ariadne When Dionysus cast his eyes upon her, he danced over to her and like a lover sat upon her lap. He took her in his arms and kissed her. Ariadne behaved modestly, but nevertheless she lovingly embraced him. When the party-guests beheld this, they kept applauding and shouting for an encore. And when Dionysus got up and drew Ariadne up with him, then you could see a real performance, as they proceeded to kiss and fondle one another. The audience saw a very good-looking Dionysus and a gorgeous Ariadne not playing a role but truly kissing each other and they all watched with great excitement. . . . In the end the dinner guests seeing the couple embracing and moving off to their marriage-bed, the unmarried ones vowed to get married, those who were already married got on their horses and rode off to visit their wives.

—XENOPHON, *Symposium* 9.4–7

The Birth, Childhood, and Origins of Dionysus

The traditional account of the birth of Dionysus (Bacchus)¹ runs as follows. Disguised as a mortal, Zeus was having an affair with **Semele**, a daughter of **Cadmus**. When Hera found out, her jealousy led her to get even. She appeared to Semele disguised as an old woman and convinced her rival that she should ask her lover to appear in the full magnificence of his divinity. Semele first persuaded Zeus to swear that he would grant whatever she might ask of him, and then she revealed her demand. Zeus was unwilling but was obliged to comply, and Semele was burned to a cinder by the splendor of his person and the fire of his lightning flash. The unborn child, being divine, was not destroyed in the conflagration; Zeus saved his son from the ashes of his mother and sewed him up in his own thigh, from which he was born again at the proper time.²

Various nurses are associated with the infant Dionysus, in particular certain nymphs of Nysa, a mountain of legendary fame located in various parts of the ancient world. Hermes, who had rescued Dionysus from Semele's ashes, carried the baby to the nymphs of Nysa. **Ino**, Semele's sister, is traditionally singled out as one who

cared for the god when he was a baby.³ When Dionysus reached manhood, he carried the message of his worship far and wide, bringing happiness and prosperity to those who would listen and madness and death to those who dared oppose. The tradition of his arrival in Greece stresses the belief that he is a latecomer to the Olympian pantheon and that his origins lie in Thrace and ultimately Phrygia.⁴ Since the name Dionysus (clearly that of the god) appears in the linear B tablets, his worship must have been introduced into Greece in the Bronze Age, earlier than previously conjectured by scholars, probably in the Mycenaean period and perhaps in the time of the legendary Cadmus, as Euripides assumes.

The *Bacchae* of Euripides

Dionysus is basically a god of vegetation in general, and in particular of the vine, the grape, and the making and drinking of wine. But his person and his teaching eventually embrace very much more. The best source for the profound meaning of his worship and its most universal implications is found in Euripides' *Bacchae* (*The Bacchic Women*). Whatever one makes of the playwright's depiction of the rites in a literal sense, the sublimity and terror of the spiritual message are inescapable and timeless. The *Bacchae* is essential for understanding the complex nature of Dionysus and his worship.



The Death of Semele, by Peter Paul Rubens (1577–1640); oil on panel, 1636, 10 ½ × 15 ½ in. Both Semele and Zeus are shown under extreme emotion—she, as death approaches, and he, rising from her couch with pity and horror, knowing her coming agony. He holds the thunderbolt back in his right hand, and his eagle grips it in its beak. (*Musées royaux des Beaux-Arts de Belgique, Bruxelles*; *Koninklijke Musea voor Schone Kunsten van België, Brussel*)

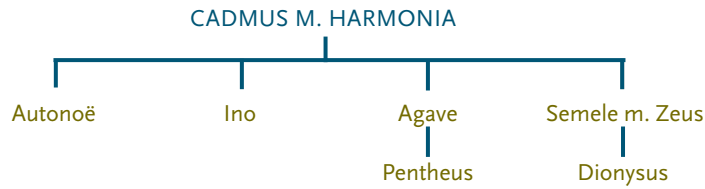


Figure 13.1. The Children of Cadmus. (A fuller genealogy for the House of Cadmus is given on p. 415.)

The play opens with Dionysus himself, who has come in anger to Thebes; his mother's integrity has been questioned by her own relatives, and the magnitude and power of his very godhead have been challenged and repudiated; the sisters of Semele claim (and **Pentheus**, grandson of Cadmus and now king of Thebes, agrees) that she became pregnant because she slept with a mortal and that Cadmus was responsible for the story that Zeus was the father of her child; as a result, Zeus killed her with a blast of lightning (1–63):



Closer Look

The Indian Triumph of Dionysus. Roman marble sarcophagus, mid-second century A.D.; width (without lid) 92 in., height 39 in., lid, width 93 in., height 12 ½ in. Dionysus rides on a chariot drawn by panthers. He is preceded by satyrs, maenads, silenoi, and animals, among which elephants and lions are prominent. He has come from India, bringing happiness and fertility to the Greek world. On the lid are reliefs of the death of Semele, the birth of Dionysus from the thigh of Zeus, and his nurture by the nymphs of Nysa. Hermes appears in each of the three scenes on the lid—rescuing the infant from the dying Semele in the left panel; taking him to the nymphs in the center panel after his birth from the thigh of Zeus, and pointing toward the scene of his nurture by the nymphs in the right panel. The sarcophagus is one of seven found in the tomb of the family of the Calpurnii Pisones in Rome. (*Sarcophagus with the Triumph of Dionysus*, Anonymous, Roman, ca. 190, Thasian marble, 47 ½ × 92 ½ × 40 × 35 13/16 in [120.7 × 234.9 × 101.6 × 90.96 cm]; Photo © The Walters Museum, Baltimore)



Audio

DIONYSUS: I, Dionysus, the son of Zeus, have come to this land of the Thebans; my mother Semele, the daughter of Cadmus, gave birth to me, delivered by a fiery blast of lightning. I am here by the stream of Dirce and the waters of the Ismenus, not as a god but in disguise as a man. I see here near the palace the shrine that commemorates my mother, who was struck dead by the lightning blast, and the ruins of her home, smoldering yet from the flame of Zeus' fire that still lives—the everlasting evidence of Hera's outrage against my mother. I am pleased with Cadmus for setting this area off as a holy sanctuary dedicated to his daughter, and I have enclosed it round about with the fresh greenery of the clustering vine. (1–12)

I left the fertile plains of gold in Lydia and Phrygia and made my way across the sunny plateaus of Persia, the walled towns of Bactria, the grim land of the Medes, rich Arabia, and the entire coast of Asia Minor, where Hellenes and non-Hellenes live together in teeming cities with beautiful towers. After having led my Bacchic dance and established my mysteries in these places, I have come to this city of the Hellenes first. (13–22)

I have raised the Bacchic cry and clothed my followers in the fawn-skin and put into their hands the thyrsus—my ivy-covered shaft—here in Thebes first of all Greece, because my mother's sisters claim (as least of all they should) that I, Dionysus, was not begotten of Zeus but that Semele became pregnant by some mortal man and through the clever instigations of Cadmus laid the blame on Zeus; they gloatingly proclaim that Zeus because of her deception struck her dead. (23–31)

And so these same sisters I have stung with madness, driving them from their homes, and they inhabit Mt. Cithaeron, bereft of sense; I have compelled them to take up the symbols of my rituals, and all the women of Thebes—the entire female population—I have driven from their homes in frenzy. Together with the daughters of Cadmus they sit out in the open air on rocks under the evergreens. For although it does not wish to, this city must learn full well that it is still not completely schooled in my Bacchic mysteries and I must defend the reputation of my mother Semele by showing myself to mortals as the god whom she bore to Zeus. (32–42)

Cadmus has handed over the prerogatives of his royal power to his daughter's son, Pentheus, who fights against my godhead, thrusting me aside in sacrifices and never mentioning my name in prayers. Therefore I shall show myself as a god to him and all the Thebans. And when I have settled matters here, I shall move on to another place and reveal myself. If the city of Thebes in anger tries by force to drive the Bacchae down from the mountains, I shall



The Birth of Dionysus. Attic red-figure lekythos, by the Alkimachos painter, ca. 460 B.C. The birth of Dionysus is not a very common subject on ancient vases. The artist of this vase has rendered the scene with sensitivity. It conveys the moment of the birth of this powerful god with stillness and a strangely detached curiosity on the part of Zeus and Hermes. Zeus, with a wreath on his head, long locks, and beard, sits naked upon a rock, covered with the garments he has just removed. Hermes, garbed in his traveling hat and winged sandals, stands waiting, intent upon the birth, dutifully holding his father's scepter in one hand and his caduceus in the other. Hermes will take the child to the nymphs of Nysa to be raised. Zeus attends to his own delivery, as his newborn son just begins to push his head out of his father's thigh. (Photograph © 2010. Museum of Fine Arts, Boston)



The Second Birth of Dionysus, by George Platt Lynes (1907–1955), 3 11/16 × 3 in. Photographer George Platt Lynes worked within a surrealist-inspired aesthetic and was particularly influential in the development of the homoerotic representation of the male nude. In his early travels abroad, particularly in France of the expatriate era (1920s and 1930s), he developed close friendships with a number of influential artists, such as Gertrude Stein, Jean Cocteau, and Monroe Wheeler (affiliated with the Museum of Modern Art in New York). In the early 1930s, he worked as a photographer for such magazines as *Harper's Bazaar* and *Vogue*. The fame of his fashion photography soon led to work as a documentary photographer for dance companies, especially George Balanchine's American Ballet Company (now the New York City Ballet), which included the ballet *Orpheus*. From 1937 to 1940, Lynes began a series of works based on Greek myth, including Endymion, Narcissus, Danaë, and the birth of Dionysus shown here. In his last years, he began an association with noted sex researcher Alfred Kinsey. Lynes himself was afraid of the reception his homoerotic images, which included some of his most creative output, would receive and had many of these destroyed. He died in poverty and almost forgotten. Subsequent exhibitions of his work since his death have reestablished him as a major photographer of the twentieth century. In the work shown here he displays a characteristic virtuosity in his use of light and shadow, together with an uncanny and unsettling focus on the pose of the figures. The naked figure of Zeus, here erotically charged, in contrast to his representation in the vase depicting the birth of Dionysus, is frozen in the moment of the agonizing pain, not to say horror, of the birth, which itself is represented in a disconcertingly and clinically realistic fashion. (© Estate of George Platt Lynes, Photo © The Metropolitan Museum of Art/Art Resource, NY)

join them in their madness as their war commander. This then is why I have assumed a mortal form and changed myself into the likeness of a man. (43–54) 40

O you women whom I have taken as companions of my journey from foreign lands, leaving the Lydian mountain Tmolus far behind, come raise the tambourines, invented by the great mother Rhea, and by me, and native to the land of Phrygia. Come and surround the royal palace of Pentheus and beat out your din so that the city of Cadmus may see. I will go to my Bacchae on the slopes of Cithaeron, where they are, and join with them in their dances. (55–63)

The chorus of women that follows reveals the exultant spirit and mystic aura surrounding the celebration of their god's mysteries (64–167):

CHORUS: Leaving Asia and holy Mt. Tmolus, we run in sweet pain and lovely weariness with ecstatic Bacchic cries in the wake of the roaring god Dionysus. Let everyone, indoors or out, keep their respectful distance and hold their tongue in sacred silence as we sing the appointed hymn to Bacchus. (64–72)



Audio



Dionysus and Maenads.

Attic red-figure amphora, by the Kleophrades painter, ca. 490 B.C.; height 56 cm. Dionysus, bearded and with long hair in ringlets down his neck, is moving to the right, though his head is turned to the left, perhaps to indicate an inebriated state. He holds a kantharos (wine cup) in his right hand and a vine branch in his left. He is wearing a dappled animal skin around his shoulders and a garland of ivy on his head. On either side of Dionysus, maenads are being assailed by satyrs. Each of the maenads is mimicking the posture of Dionysus, moving in one direction toward the god while facing the other. Both maenads carry the thyrsus, and the maenad on the left is also holding a serpent. On the neck, three athletes are seen with discus and spear. (*Staatliche Antikensammlungen und Glyptothek München*. Photograph by Renate Kühling)

Happy is the one who, blessed with the knowledge of the divine mysteries, leads a life of ritual purity and joins the holy group of revelers, heart and soul, as they honor their god Bacchus in the mountains with holy ceremonies of purification. He participates in mysteries ordained by the great mother, Cybele herself, as he follows his god, Dionysus, brandishing a thyrsus. (73–82)

Run, run, Bacchae, bringing the roaring god, Dionysus, son of a god, out of the Phrygian mountains to the spacious streets of Hellas. (83–87) 10

Once when his mother carried him in her womb, the lightning bolt flew from the hand of Zeus and she brought the child forth prematurely with the pains of a labor forced on her too soon, and she gave up her life in the fiery blast. Immediately Zeus, the son of Cronus, took up the child and enclosed him in the secret recess of his thigh with fastenings of gold, and hid him from Hera thus in a second womb. When the Fates had so decreed, Zeus bore the bull-horned god and wreathed his head with a crown of serpents, and so the Maenads hunt and catch wild snakes and twine them in their hair. (88–104)

O Thebes, crown yourself with ivy, burst forth luxuriant in verdant leaves and lovely berries; join the Bacchic frenzy with branches torn from trees of oak or fir and consecrate your cloak of dappled fawnskin with white tufts of purest wool. Be reverent with the violent powers of the thyrsus. Straightway the whole land will dance its way (whoever leads the sacred group represents the roaring god himself) to the mountain, to the mountain where the crowd of women waits, driven from their labors at the loom by the maddening sting of Dionysus. (105–119) 20

O secret chamber on Crete, holy cavern where Zeus was born, attended by the Curetes!⁵ Here the Corybantes with their three-crested helmets invented for us this drum of hide stretched tight and their ecstatic revels mingled its tense beat with the sweet alluring breath of the Phrygian flutes, and they put it into the hand of mother Rhea, so that she might beat an accompaniment to the cries of her Bacchic women. The satyrs in their frenzy took up the drum from the mother-goddess and added it to the music of their dances during the festivities in which Dionysus delights. (120–134) 30

How sweet it is in the mountains when, out of the rushing throng, the priest of the roaring god falls to the ground in his quest for blood and with a joyful cry devours the raw flesh of the slaughtered goat. The plain flows with milk and wine and the nectar of bees; but the Bacchic celebrant runs on, brandishing his pine torch, and the flame streams behind with smoke as sweet as Syrian frankincense. He urges on the wandering band with shouts and renews their frenzied dancing, as his delicate locks toss in the breeze. (135–150) 40

Amid the frantic shouts is heard his thunderous cry: "Run, run, Bacchae, you the pride of Tmolus with its streams of gold. Celebrate the god Dionysus on your thundering drums, honoring this deity of joy with Phrygian cries and shouts of ecstasy, while the melodious and holy flute sounds its sacred accompaniment as you throng, to the mountain, to the mountain." (151–165)

Every Bacchanal runs and leaps in joy, just like a foal that frisks beside her mother in the pasture.

The scene that follows (170–313) is fraught with tragic humor and bitter irony. Cadmus (retired king) and Tiresias (priest of the traditional religion) welcome the new god with motives that are startling in their blatant pragmatism. Each of them sees personal advantage in accepting the rites of the new god. In their joyous rejuvenation, these two old men, experienced realists, present just the

right foil for the introduction of the doomed Pentheus, who, in his mortal blindness, dares to challenge the god, his cousin, Dionysus.

TIRESIAS: Who attends at the gate? Summon Cadmus from the house, the son of Agenor, who came from Sidonia and fortified the city of the Thebans. Let someone go and announce that Tiresias wants to see him. He already knows for what reason I have come. I made an agreement with him, even though I am old and he is even older, to make myself a thyrsus, wear a fawnskin, and crown my head with shoots of ivy. (170–177)

CADMUS: My dearest friend, I knew your voice from inside the palace, and recognized the wise words of a wise man. I have come ready with the paraphernalia of the god. For since Dionysus, who has revealed himself to mortals as a god, is the son of my daughter, I must do everything in my power to magnify his greatness. Where should we go to join the others in the dance, shaking our gray heads in ecstasy? Tell me, an old man, Tiresias, for you are old too and wise. I shall never grow tired by night or by day as I strike the ground with my thyrsus. It will be a sweet pleasure to forget that we are old. (178–188)

TIRESIAS: You experience the same sensations as I do, for I feel young again and I shall attempt the dance.

CADMUS: Shall we not proceed to the mountain by chariot?

TIRESIAS: No, the god would not have as appropriate an honor.

CADMUS: I will lead the way for you, two old men together.

TIRESIAS: The god will lead the two of us there without any difficulty. 20

CADMUS: Are we to be the only men of the city to dance in honor of Bacchus? (195)

TIRESIAS: We are the only ones who think the way one should; the others are wrong and perverse.

CADMUS: We delay too long; give me your hand.

TIRESIAS: Here it is, take hold and join our hands together.

CADMUS: Being a mere mortal, I am not scornful of the gods.

TIRESIAS: About the gods we have no new wise speculations. The ancestral beliefs that we hold are as old as time, and they cannot be destroyed by any argument or clever subtlety invented by profound minds. How could I help being ashamed, one will ask, as I am about to join in the dance, at my age, with an ivy wreath on my head? The god does not discriminate whether young or old must dance in his honor, but he desires to be esteemed by all alike and wishes his glory to be magnified, making no distinctions whatsoever. (200–209) 20

CADMUS: Since you are blind, Tiresias, I shall be a prophet for you, and tell you what I see. Pentheus, the son of Echion, to whom I have given my royal power in Thebes, comes in haste to this palace. How excited he is; what news has he to tell us? (210–214)

PENTHEUS: Although I happened to have been away from Thebes, I have heard of the new evils that beset the city; the women have abandoned our homes on the pretense of Bacchic rites and gad about on the dark mountainside honoring by their dances the new god, Dionysus, whoever he is. Bowls full of wine stand in the midst of each group, and they sneak away one by one to solitary places where they satisfy the lust of males. Their pretext is that they are Maenad priestesses, but they put Aphrodite ahead of Bacchus. All those I have caught are kept safe with their hands tied by guards in the state prison. The others, who still roam on the mountain, I shall hunt out, including my own mother, Agave, and 40

her sisters, Ino and Autonoë, the mother of Actaeon. And when I have bound them fast in iron chains, I shall soon put an end to this evil Bacchism. (215–232)

They say too that a stranger has come here from Lydia, some wizard and sorcerer, with scented hair and golden curls, who has the wine-dark charms of Aphrodite in his eyes. He spends both night and day in the company of young girls, enticing them with his Bacchic mysteries. If I catch him here in my palace, I'll cut off his head and put a stop to his thyrsus-pounding and head-tossing. That fellow is the one who claims that Dionysus is a god, who was once sewn up in the thigh of Zeus, when he was in fact destroyed by the fiery blast of lightning along with his mother, because she lied and said that Zeus had been her husband. Whoever this stranger may be, does he not deserve to hang for such hubris? (233–247) 50

But here is another miracle—I see the prophet Tiresias in a dappled fawn-skin, and my mother's father, a very funny sight, playing the Bacchant with a wand of fennel reed. I refuse, sir, to stand by and see you behave so senselessly in your old age. You are my grandfather; won't you toss away your garland of ivy and rid your hand of the thyrsus? (248–254) 60

You persuaded him, Tiresias. Why? By introducing this new divinity among people do you hope that he will afford you an additional source of income from your omens and your sacrifices? If it were not for your gray hairs, you would not escape being bound and imprisoned along with the Bacchae for initiating evil rites. As far as women are concerned, I maintain that whenever the gleam of wine is in their feasts, there can be nothing further that is wholesome in their ceremonies. (255–262) 70

CHORUS: What sacrilege, sir! Do you not have respect for the gods and Cadmus, who sowed the seeds from which the earthborn men arose; are you, the son of Echion, who was one of them, bringing shame on your own family? (262–265)

TIRESIAS: Whenever a wise man takes a good theme for his argument, it is no great task to speak well. You seem to be a man of intelligence from the glibness of your tongue, but there is no good sense in your words. A headstrong man who is powerful and eloquent proves to be a bad citizen because he is wanting in intelligence. This new divinity whom you laugh at—I could not begin to tell you how great he will become throughout Hellas. . . .⁶ (266–274)

Pentheus, believe me; do not be overly confident that force is all-powerful in human affairs, and do not think that you are wise when the attitude that you hold is sick. Receive the god into the city, pour him libations, crown your head, and celebrate his worship. (309–313) 80

Tiresias goes on to argue that self-control is a question of one's own nature and character. Dionysus is not immoral; he cannot corrupt a chaste woman or restrain a promiscuous one. Besides, the god (just like Pentheus himself) is happy to receive the homage of his people.

Cadmus reinforces Tiresias' appeal for reason and control. Pentheus must be sick to defy the god; and even if he were right and Dionysus were an impostor, he should be willing to compromise and lie in order to save the honor of Semele and the whole family. But Pentheus is young and adamant; he accuses his peers of folly and madness and directs one of his henchmen to smash Tiresias' place of augury (after all, has he not himself desecrated his own priestly office?) and to hunt down the effeminate foreigner who has corrupted the women of Thebes.

A guard brings in the exotic stranger who has come with his new religion (in reality, he is Dionysus himself), and Euripides presents the first of three interviews

between the god and the man which turn upon the ironic reversal of their positions. Pentheus, believing himself triumphant, is gradually but inevitably caught in the net prepared for him by Dionysus. The calm and sure strength of the god plays beautifully upon the neurotic impulsiveness of the mortal (434–518):

Guard: Pentheus, here we are, having hunted the quarry you sent us after, and our efforts have not been unsuccessful. But we found this wild beast tame—he did not attempt to flee but gave me his hands willingly; he did not even turn pale but kept the flush of wine in his cheeks. With a smile he bade me tie him up and lead him away and waited for me, thus making my task easy. I was taken aback and said: “O stranger, I do not arrest you of my own free will but at the orders of Pentheus who has sent me.” (434–442)

About the Bacchae whom you seized and bound and imprisoned—they are freed and have gone and dance about the glens calling on their god, Bacchus. The bonds fell from their feet of their own accord, and the locks on the door gave way untouched by mortal hands. This man who has come to our city of Thebes is full of many miraculous wonders—and what else will happen is your concern, not mine. (443–450)

PENTHEUS: Untie his hands. Now that he is in my trap, he is not nimble enough to escape me. Well, stranger, you are not unattractive physically—at least to women—and, after all, your purpose in Thebes is to lure them. Your flowing locks that ripple down your cheeks so seductively prove that you are no wrestler. Your fair complexion too is cultivated by avoiding the rays of the sun and by keeping in the shade so that you may ensnare Aphrodite with your beauty. But first tell me where you come from. (451–460)

DIONYSUS: I can answer your question easily and simply. I am sure you have heard of the mountain of Tmolus with its flowers.

PENTHEUS: I have; its range encircles the city of Sardis.

DIONYSUS: I am from there; Lydia is my fatherland.

PENTHEUS: How is it that you bring these mysteries of yours to Hellas? (465)

DIONYSUS: Dionysus, the son of Zeus, has directed me.

PENTHEUS: Is there a Zeus in Lydia who begets new gods?

DIONYSUS: No, he is the same Zeus who wedded Semele here in Thebes.

PENTHEUS: Did he bend you to his service, an apparition in the night, or did you really see him with your own eyes? 30

DIONYSUS: We saw each other face to face, and he gave me his secrets. (470)

PENTHEUS: What is the nature of these secrets of yours?

DIONYSUS: It is not lawful for the uninitiated to know them.

PENTHEUS: What advantage is there for those who do participate?

DIONYSUS: It is not right for you to learn this, but the knowledge is worth much.

PENTHEUS: Your answer is clever, designed to make me want to hear more. (475)

DIONYSUS: An impious man is abhorred by the god and his mysteries.

PENTHEUS: You say that you saw the god clearly; well then, what did he look like? 40

DIONYSUS: He looked as he wished; I had no control over his appearance.

PENTHEUS: Once again you have sidetracked me cleverly with an answer that says nothing.

DIONYSUS: The words of the wise seem foolish to the ignorant. (480)

PENTHEUS: Have you come here first of all to introduce your god?



Audio

DIONYSUS: Every foreigner already dances his rituals.
 PENTHEUS: Yes, of course, for they are far inferior to Hellenes.
 DIONYSUS: Customs differ, but in these rituals the foreigners are superior.
 PENTHEUS: Do you perform your holy rites by night or by day? (485)
 DIONYSUS: By night for the most part; darkness adds to the solemnity. 50
 PENTHEUS: For women it is treacherous and corrupt.
 DIONYSUS: One may find, if one looks for it, shameful behavior by daylight too.
 PENTHEUS: You must be punished for your evil sophistries.
 DIONYSUS: And you for your ignorance and blasphemy against the god. (490)
 PENTHEUS: How bold our Bacchant is and how facile his retorts.
 DIONYSUS: What punishment must I suffer? What terrible thing will you do to me?
 PENTHEUS: First I shall cut your pretty locks.
 DIONYSUS: My hair is sacred; it belongs to the god.
 PENTHEUS: Hand over your thyrsus then. (495) 60
 DIONYSUS: Take it away from me yourself. I carry it for Dionysus; it really belongs to him.
 PENTHEUS: I shall close you up in a prison.
 DIONYSUS: The god himself will free me, whenever I wish.
 PENTHEUS: As you call on him when you take your stand amid your Bacchic women, I suppose.
 DIONYSUS: Even now he is near at hand and sees what I endure. (500)
 PENTHEUS: Where is he? My eyes cannot see him.
 DIONYSUS: Here with me. But you in your blasphemy cannot perceive him for yourself. 70
 PENTHEUS: Guards, seize him; he is making a fool of me and of all Thebes.
 DIONYSUS: I tell you not to bind me—I am the sane one, not you.
 PENTHEUS: My orders are to bind you, and I have the upper hand. (505)
 DIONYSUS: You do not know what life you live, what you do, or who you are.
 PENTHEUS: I am Pentheus, the son of Agave; my father is Echion.
 DIONYSUS: Your name, Pentheus, which means sorrow, is appropriate for the doom that will be yours.
 PENTHEUS: Get out of here—Guards, imprison him in the neighboring stables where he may find his secret darkness—do your mystic dances there. And the women you have brought with you as accomplices in your evil I shall either keep 80
 as slaves myself to work the loom or sell them to others—this will stop their hands from beating out their din on tambourines. (509–514)
 DIONYSUS: I will go, since what is not destined to be, I am not destined to suffer. But Dionysus, who you say does not exist, will exact vengeance for your insolence. For as you do me wrong and imprison me, you do the same to him. (515–518)

Pentheus confidently follows Dionysus into the prison. But the god miraculously frees himself amid fire, earthquake, and the destruction of the entire palace. He explains to the chorus how he has escaped from Pentheus' evil clutches, maintaining throughout the fiction of his role as the god's disciple. Quite typically Dionysus is associated with or transformed into an animal (616–636):

DIONYSUS: I have made a fool of Pentheus—he thought that he was tying me up, yet he did not so much as lay a finger on me but fed on empty hopes. In

the chamber where he led me a prisoner, he found a bull. It was the knees and hoofs of this animal that he tried to bind, fuming and raging, biting his lips, and dripping with sweat, while I sat calmly close by his side and watched. In this crisis Bacchus arrived and made the building shake and raised a flame up from the tomb of his mother. When Pentheus saw it, he thought that the palace was on fire and rushed this way and that, calling on the servants to bring water. The entire household joined in the work, but their toil was for nothing. Pentheus, thinking that I had got away, abandoned his efforts and seized a dark sword and rushed inside the palace in pursuit. (616–628) 10

Then Dionysus created an illusion in the courtyard (I am telling you what I believe happened), and Pentheus made a dash for it, jabbing and stabbing at the sunny air, imagining he was butchering me. Bacchus had even greater humiliation for him than this. He razed the whole palace to the ground; all lies shattered for him as he beholds the most bitter results of my imprisonment. Worn out and exhausted, he has dropped his sword; a mere mortal, he dared to go to battle against a god. (629–636)

As Dionysus coolly finishes his account, Pentheus appears, bewildered, angry, and, despite his experience, still relentlessly aggressive. A brief exchange between the two is interrupted by the arrival of a messenger, who reports what he and others have seen of the Bacchic women and their worship in the mountains; at first a calm, peaceful scene full of miracles, then madness and bloodshed when the interlopers are detected—a grim foreshadowing of what is in store for Pentheus (677–774):

MESSANGER: I had just reached the hill country with my pasturing herds by the time that the sun had risen and was warming the earth with its rays. And I saw the women, who had arranged themselves in three groups; Autonoë led one, your mother, Agave, the second, and Ino, the third. All were stretched out asleep, some reclined on beds of fir, others rested their heads on oak leaves, having flung themselves down at random but with modesty; and they were not, as you said they would be, intoxicated with wine and the music of the flute, bent on satisfying their lust in solitary places. (677–688)

When your mother heard the sounds of our horned cattle, she stood up in the midst of the Bacchae, and cried out to rouse them from their sleep, and they threw off the heavy slumber from their eyes and jumped up—amazing in their orderliness, young and old (many still unwed). The first thing they did was to loosen their hair to their shoulders and tie up their fawnskins if any of the fastenings had come loose; and they made a belt for the dappled fur with snakes that licked their cheeks. Some held in their arms the young of the wild, a gazelle or wolf cubs, and those who had left their newborn babes at home gave them white milk from breasts that were still full. (689–702) 10

And they put on crowns of ivy, oak, and flowering vine. One took her thyrsus and struck it against a rock, and from it a gush of dewy water welled up; another hit the solid earth with her wand, and from the spot the god sent forth a spring of wine. Those who thirsted for milk scraped the earth with their fingertips and produced white streams; and from each thyrsus, wreathed in ivy, dripped sweet drops of honey. And so, if you had been there to see these things, you would have invoked with prayers the god whom you now blame. (702–713) 20



Dionysus, Maenads, and Satyrs. Attic black-figure kylix by Nikosthenes, ca. 520 B.C. Dionysus sits on a square chair on the right, holding a rhyton (a drinking horn with a hole in the narrow end through which the wine flowed) in his right hand, with a stylized crown or garland on his head. Around the kylix are dancing ithyphallic satyrs and maenads. Note the double “flute” (a reed instrument) played by the satyr to the left of Dionysus, and the wine jug in the left hand of the maenad to the right of Dionysus. The scene is decorated with trailing vine-leaves and clusters of grapes: in the center is a running winged Gorgon. (© RMN (Musée du Louvre)/Hervé Lewandowski)

We herdsmen and shepherds gathered together to discuss and argue about the strange and wondrous actions. One of the group, who always goes into town and has a way with words, spoke to us all: “You who inhabit the sacred mountain heights, how would you like to hunt down Agave, the mother of Pentheus, in her revels and do the king a favor?” What he said seemed good to us, so we hid ourselves in a leafy thicket and waited in ambush. At the appointed time they began their Bacchic revels, shaking their thyrsus and calling on the god, the son of Zeus, with one voice “Iacchus, Bromius!” The whole mountain and animals joined in their ecstasy and there was nothing that remained unmoved by the dance. (714–727) 30

It happened that Agave, as she leaped and ran, came close to me, and I leaped out of the ambush where I had hidden myself, bent on seizing her. But she cried aloud: “O my swift-running hounds, we are being hunted by these men; so follow me, follow, armed with your thyrsus in your hands.” (728–733)

And so we fled and escaped being torn into pieces by the Bacchae, but with their bare hands they attacked our cattle grazing on the grass. You could see one of them wrenching apart a bellowing cow, its udders full. Others ripped apart the calves, and you could see ribs and cloven hoofs being scattered high 40

and low, and from the pines the pieces hung dripping with blood. Bulls, arrogant before as they raged with their horns, were laid low, dragged bodily to the ground by the countless hands of girls; and their flesh was stripped from their bodies more quickly than you, O king, could wink your eyes. (734–747)

Like birds propelled aloft by the speed of their course, the Bacchae ranged across the stretch of plain along the stream of the Asopus, which affords the Thebans a rich harvest. Like a hostile army they descended upon the villages of Hysiae and Erythrae, nestled low on the slopes of Cithaeron, and devastated them. They snatched children from their homes, and all the booty (including bronze and iron) that they carried off on their shoulders did not fall onto the dark earth, although it was not fastened. They bore fire on their hair and it did not burn. The villagers, enraged by the plundering of the Bacchae, rushed to arms. (748–759)

Then, my king, there was a terrifying sight to behold. The weapons that the villagers threw did not draw any blood, but when the Bacchae hurled the thyrsus from their hands they inflicted wounds on many. Women routed men—a feat not to be accomplished without the power of some god. Back they came to where they sallied forth, to the very streams which the god made gush for them. They washed their hands of blood, and snakes licked the stains from their cheeks. (760–768)

And so, my lord, receive into the city this god, whoever he is. He is great in many respects but especially in his reputed gift to mortals, about which I have heard, the grape, our remedy for pain and sorrow. With no more wine, there could be no more love and no other pleasure for humankind besides. (769–774)

Pentheus refuses to listen to the pleas of the messenger. He is determined to make an armed assault on the Bacchae. But the stranger, Dionysus, finds a way to restrain him by appealing to Pentheus' basic nature and psychology—in general, the complex neurosis that stems from his repressions; in particular, his prurient preoccupation with sex and his desire to see the orgies that he insists are taking place (811–861):

DIONYSUS: Would you like to see the women banded together in the mountains? (811)

PENTHEUS: Yes, indeed. I would give a ton of gold for that.

DIONYSUS: Why are you driven by such a great desire to see them?

PENTHEUS: Actually, it would pain me to see them drunk.

DIONYSUS: Nevertheless, you would be pleased to see what is painful to you? (815)

PENTHEUS: To be sure, if I watched in silence crouched beneath the firs.

DIONYSUS: But they will track you down, even if you go in secret.

PENTHEUS: Then I shall go openly; what you say is right.

DIONYSUS: You will undergo the journey then? Let me lead you.

PENTHEUS: Come, as quickly as possible; I begrudge you this delay. (820)

DIONYSUS: Then dress up in a fine linen robe.

PENTHEUS: What is this? Am I to change from a man to a woman?

DIONYSUS: If you are seen there as a man, they will kill you.

PENTHEUS: Again, what you say is right. You are like some sage of long ago.

DIONYSUS: Dionysus gives me this inspiration. (825)

PENTHEUS: How may what you advise best be accomplished?

DIONYSUS: I will go inside and dress you up there.
 PENTHEUS: In the garb of a woman? But shame holds me back! 20
 DIONYSUS: You are no longer interested in watching the Maenads?
 PENTHEUS: What dress did you say that you would put on me? (830)
 DIONYSUS: I shall set on your head a long flowing wig.
 PENTHEUS: And what is the next feature of my outfit?
 DIONYSUS: A robe that falls to your feet and a band around your head.
 PENTHEUS: What else will you give me?
 DIONYSUS: A thyrsus in your hand and a dappled fawnskin cloak. (835)
 PENTHEUS: I cannot bring myself to put on the costume of a woman.
 DIONYSUS: But if you attack the Bacchae in battle, you will shed blood.
 PENTHEUS: This is true; I must first go as a spy. 30
 DIONYSUS: To be sure, it is wiser than to hunt out evil by evil.
 PENTHEUS: How shall I get out of the city without being seen? (840)
 DIONYSUS: We shall take a deserted route, and I shall lead the way.
 PENTHEUS: Anything, rather than have the Bacchae laugh at me. I shall go into
 the house and make preparations that are for the best.
 DIONYSUS: So be it, and I am at your side ready for everything.
 PENTHEUS: I am going inside; I shall either proceed with arms or follow your
 instructions. (845–846)
 DIONYSUS: Women, this man is ready to be caught in the net. He will go to the
 Bacchae, and he will pay the penalty with his life. Dionysus, now do your work; 40
 for you are not far away. We shall exact our retribution. First we shall inflict upon
 him delirious madness and drive him out of his wits; in his right mind, he would
 not want to dress up in the costume of a woman; but once driven from reason
 he will put it on. My desire is to make him the laughingstock of the Thebans as
 they see him led in a woman's garb through the city in return for the terrible
 threats that he uttered before. I go now to deck out Pentheus in the dress with
 which he will go down to the realm of Hades, slaughtered by the hands of his
 mother. He will know Dionysus as the son of Zeus and a deity of his own right,
 among humankind most dread and most gentle. (847–861)

The dressing of Pentheus in the garb of the Bacchae suggests the ceremonial decking out of the sacrificial victim. By the ritual of donning his costume, Pentheus falls under the spell and the power of the god, eventually to be offered up to him. The chorus sings of the joys of their worship and the justice of their triumph over impiety; and at the end of their song, Dionysus exerts final and complete mastery over Pentheus, who is delirious (912–970):

DIONYSUS: Pentheus, I call on you, the one who desires to see what he should
 not see and hastens upon what he should not do. Come forward out of the
 house, let me behold you dressed in the garb of a woman, a Bacchic Maenad,
 about to go as a spy on your mother and her group. (912–917)
 PENTHEUS: I think that I see two suns, and the image of Thebes with its seven
 gates appears double. You look like a bull as you lead me forward, with horns
 growing out of your head. Were you then an animal? Now, indeed, you have
 become a bull. (918–922)
 DIONYSUS: The god walks with us; he is on our side. although he was not
 kindly disposed before. Now you see what you should see. 10
 PENTHEUS: Tell me how I look. Do I not have the bearing of Ino or my mother,
 Agave?

DIONYSUS: Looking at you, I seem to see those very two. But this lock here that I had fixed under your hairband has fallen out of place. (927–929)

PENTHEUS: I shook it loose indoors while I was tossing my head back and forth like a Bacchic reveler.

DIONYSUS: Well we, whose concern is to serve you, shall put it back in place. Bend your head. (932–933)

PENTHEUS: Fine, you deck me out properly, for I am now dedicated to you.

DIONYSUS: Your belt is loose and the folds of your dress do not hang straight 10
to your ankles.

PENTHEUS: They are not straight at the right foot, but here on the left the dress hangs well at the heel. (937–938)

DIONYSUS: You will, I am sure, consider me the best of your friends, when contrary to your expectation you witness the temperance of the Bacchae.

PENTHEUS: Shall I be more like one of the Bacchae if I hold my thyrsus in my right or my left hand? (941–942)

DIONYSUS: You should hold it in your right hand, and raise it and your right foot at the same time.

PENTHEUS: Will I be able to lift up on my shoulders Mt. Cithaeron with its 30
glens full of Bacchae? (945–946)

DIONYSUS: You will, if you wish; before your mind was not sound, but now it is as it ought to be.

PENTHEUS: Let us take crowbars, or shall I thrust my shoulder or my arm under the peaks and crush them with my hands?

DIONYSUS: Do not destroy the haunts of the nymphs and the places where Pan does his piping. (951–952)

PENTHEUS: Your words are right; women must not be overcome by force; I will hide myself among the firs.

DIONYSUS: You will find the hiding place that you should, coming upon the 40
Maenads as a crafty spy. (955–956)

PENTHEUS: Indeed, I can see them now in the bushes like birds held fast in the enticing coils of love.

DIONYSUS: Yes, of course, you go on a mission to guard against this very thing. Maybe you will catch them, if you yourself are not caught first.

PENTHEUS: Take me through the middle of Thebes, for I am the only man among them who dares this deed. (961–962)

DIONYSUS: You alone bear the burden of toil for this city—you alone. And so the struggle which must be awaits you. Follow me; I shall lead you there in safety, but another will lead you back. 50

PENTHEUS: My mother. (966)

DIONYSUS: A spectacle for all.

PENTHEUS: It is for this I am going.

DIONYSUS: You will be carried home.

PENTHEUS: What luxury you are suggesting.

DIONYSUS: In the hands of your mother. (969)

PENTHEUS: You insist upon pampering me.

DIONYSUS: Pampering of sorts.

PENTHEUS: Worthy of such rewards, I follow you. (970)

Pentheus imagines he will return in a splendid carriage, with his mother by his side. This terrifying scene is built on more than this one irony and is laden

with a multiplicity of ambiguities. Pentheus the transvestite imagines, like a child, loving care at the hands of his mother. How bitter now appear the earlier taunts of Pentheus against Cadmus and Tiresias! In his delirium, does Pentheus really see the god in his true and basic character—a beast? Or does his vision spring from his own warped interpretation of the bestial nature of the worship?

Ambiguity, very much a part of the Dionysian experience, runs throughout the play. In the description of the Bacchae we hear two stories, one of serenity and tranquility on the mountains, where man and nature are in harmony, another of unnatural acts and violent and bloody sacrifice. Dionysus himself is both gentle and terrifying, powerless and potent, a giver of joy and pain. Pentheus' vision is confused, when he sees within the same person a bull and the smiling figure of a man. In the end, Pentheus becomes the hunter and the hunted, an adversary of the god and a devotee, concerned with the proper dress and carriage of a bacchant. He who wanted to see will be seen. He who wanted to battle a god will be possessed by him and become his sacrificial victim.

A messenger arrives to tell of Pentheus' horrifying death (1043–1152):



Audio

MESSANGER: When we had left the town of Thebes behind and crossed the stream of the Asopus, we made our way up the slopes of Cithaeron, Pentheus and I (for I followed with my master) and the stranger who led us to the scene. (1043–1047)

First we took a position in a grassy glen, with silent footsteps and not a word, so that we might see and not be seen. It was a valley surrounded by cliffs, watered by streams, and shaded by pines; here Maenads sat, their hands occupied in their joyous tasks. Some were restoring a crown of ivy on a thyrsus that had lost its foliage; others, happy as fillies let loose from their painted yokes, were singing Bacchic hymns in answering refrains. (1048–1057)

But poor Pentheus, who could not see this crowd of women, said: "My friend, from where I stand I am too far away to see these counterfeit Maenads clearly, but if I climbed up a towering pine on the hillside, I could properly behold the orgies of the Maenads." Then and there I saw the stranger do wondrous things. He took hold of the very top branch of a pine that reached up to the sky and pulled it down, down, down to the black earth. And it was bent like a bow or the curving line of the circle of a wheel. Thus the stranger grabbed the mountain pine with his hands and bent it to the ground, a feat no mortal could accomplish. (1058–1069)

He sat Pentheus on the topmost branches and let the tree go, sliding it through his hands until it was upright again, slowly and carefully so that he might not dislodge him. It towered straight to towering heaven, with our king perched on top. He could be seen more clearly by the Maenads than he could see them. He was just becoming visible, seated aloft, when the stranger was no longer to be seen, and from heaven a voice (I imagine that of Dionysus) cried aloud: "O women, I bring the man who made a mockery of you and me and our mysteries; now take vengeance on him." (1070–1081)

As the voice spoke these words, a blaze of holy fire flashed between heaven and earth. The air grew still, every leaf in the wooded glen stood silent, and no sound of a beast was to be heard. The women had not made out the voice clearly, and they stood up straight and looked around. He called again, and when the daughters of Cadmus understood the clear command of Bacchus, they rushed forth as swift as doves in their relentless course, his mother, Agave, her sisters, and all the Bacchae. With a madness inspired by the breath of the